The survey team left at dawn and walked
north along the dry river bed, counting
every heron they saw on the far bank.
By noon the heat was heavy and they
rested under the old fig near the ford.

In the afternoon the second team took
the boat downstream to the salt flats,
where the water turned grey and still.
They logged forty plovers and a pair
of spoonbills feeding in the shallows.

1 Herons were counted twice on the first morning and the totals were corrected later that week.

2 The salt flats are closed to boats in winter so the second route was only possible in summer.